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Integer equations

Level 3 Senior · Number theory

Solve equations in integers by factorising, using parity and remainders to rule out cases, bounding, and finding every solution of $ax + by = c$.

By the end you can: You will be able to rearrange an equation into a product equal to a constant and list every solution; You will be able to use parity and small moduli to prove an equation has no solutions or to cut down cases; You will be able to bound variables to finitely many cases and solve linear equations ax + by = c completely.

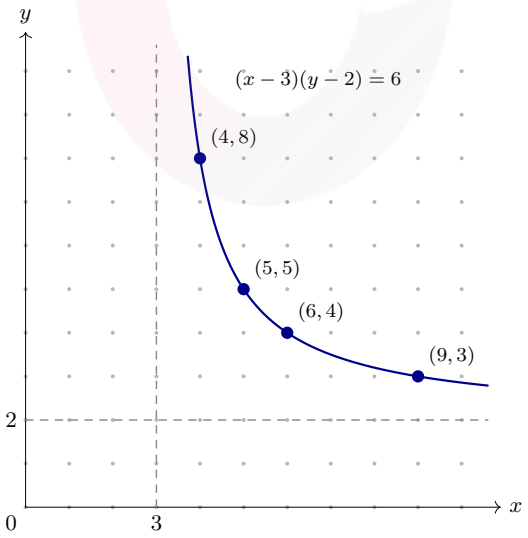
Lesson

Find all pairs of positive integers (x, y) with $xy = 2x + 3y$.

Over the real numbers this has infinitely many solutions: choose any $x \neq 3$ and put $y = 2x/(x-3)$. Over the integers, move everything to one side to get $xy-2x-3y = 0$, and note that $(x-3)(y-2) = xy - 2x - 3y + 6$. So the equation says

$$(x-3)(y-2) = 6.$$

Two integers multiply to 6, so each is a divisor of 6, and there are only finitely many of those. Since $x, y \geq 1$ we have $x - 3 \geq -2$ and $y - 2 \geq -1$, so a negative factorisation of 6 would need a factor below its allowed minimum; hence both factors are positive. The pairs $1 \cdot 6$, $2 \cdot 3$, $3 \cdot 2$, $6 \cdot 1$ give $(x, y) = (4, 8), (5, 5), (6, 4), (9, 3)$, the complete list. The curve has infinitely many points, but only four lattice points.



At this level there are three main methods: factorising (a product equal to a constant), remainders (to rule out or restrict cases) and bounding (to reduce to finitely many cases). Linear equations $ax + by = c$ have a complete theory of their own.

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Factorising: make a product equal a constant

The principle. If $AB = N$, where A and B are integers and $N \neq 0$ is fixed, then A is a divisor of N (positive or negative) and $B = N/A$. So there are finitely many possibilities, and you can list them.

The difficulty is in getting the equation into that shape. Three standard moves cover most cases.

- *Completing the product.* Since $(x+b)(y+a) = xy+ax+by+ab$, the equation $xy+ax+by = c$ becomes $(x+b)(y+a) = c+ab$. If the xy term has a coefficient, multiply through by it first.
- *Difference of two squares.* $x^2 - y^2 = N$ becomes $(x-y)(x+y) = N$.
- *Completing the square first.* For example $x^2+6x = y^2$ becomes $(x+3)^2 - y^2 = 9$, a difference of two squares.

A difference of squares gives extra information: $x-y$ and $x+y$ differ by $2y$, so they have the same parity.

Theorem. An integer N is a difference of two squares of integers if and only if N is odd or a multiple of 4.

Proof. Every square is $\equiv 0$ or $1 \pmod 4$, so a difference of two squares is $\equiv 0, 1$ or $3 \pmod 4$, never 2. Conversely, $2k+1 = (k+1)^2 - k^2$ and $4k = (k+1)^2 - (k-1)^2$. ■

When you list factor pairs $N = de$ with $d = x-y$ and $e = x+y$, keep only the pairs where d and e have the same parity. Then $x = (d+e)/2$ and $y = (e-d)/2$.

Example 1. Find all positive integers n for which $n^2 + 20n + 11$ is a perfect square.

Solution.
Trying $n = 1, 2, 3, 4$ gives $32, 55, 80, 107$, with no sign of when we could stop. So set $n^2+20n+11 = m^2$ with $m \geq 0$ and complete the square: $(n+10)^2 - 89 = m^2$, that is,

$$(n+10-m)(n+10+m) = 89.$$

The second factor is positive, so the first is too, and the second is the larger. Since 89 is prime, the only option is $n+10+m = 89$ and $n+10-m = 1$. Adding, $2(n+10) = 90$, so $n = 35$ and $m = 44$. Check: $35^2 + 700 + 11 = 1936 = 44^2$. The only answer is $n = 35$.
There is a second method, which still works when factorising does not. We have $n^2+20n+11 < (n+10)^2$ for every n, and $(n+9)^2 = n^2+18n+81$ is less than $n^2+20n+11$ exactly when $2n > 70$. So for $n > 35$ the number lies between two consecutive squares, equal to neither, and cannot be a square. That leaves only $n \leq 35$ to check. This squeeze between consecutive squares is a standard bounding method.

Remainders: parity and other moduli

If an equation has a solution in integers, then it has a solution modulo every n. So if one modulus makes the two sides disagree whatever the variables are, there are no solutions at all. This is the standard way to prove impossibility, and it also cuts down cases when solutions exist.

Squares and cubes modulo small numbers.

- Modulo 3 and modulo 4, every square is 0 or 1.

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- Modulo 8, every square is 0, 1 or 4, and every odd square is 1.
- Modulo 7 and modulo 9, every cube is 0, 1 or -1.

Each is checked by running through the residues. The odd-square fact is worth remembering with its proof: $(2k+1)^2 = 4k(k+1)+1$, and $k(k+1)$ is even, so 8 divides $4k(k+1)$.

Example 2. Show that the equation $x^2 - 3y^2 = 2026$ has no solutions in integers.

Solution.
We look for a modulus in which the equation is impossible. The coefficient 3 suggests modulo 3 first, where the equation becomes $x^2 \equiv 2026 \equiv 1 \pmod 3$, which is possible.
Next try modulo 4, where $-3 \equiv 1$: we need $x^2 + y^2 \equiv 2026 \equiv 2 \pmod 4$. Squares are 0 or 1 modulo 4, so this forces $x^2 \equiv y^2 \equiv 1$, which means x and y are both odd. This is not yet a contradiction, but modulo 8 can use it.
With x and y odd, $x^2 \equiv y^2 \equiv 1 \pmod 8$, so $x^2 - 3y^2 \equiv 1 - 3 = -2 \equiv 6 \pmod 8$. But $2026 = 8 \cdot 253 + 2 \equiv 2 \pmod 8$. This is a contradiction, so there are no solutions.
When a modulus gives no contradiction, use what it does tell you to choose the next one. For squares, modulo 4 followed by modulo 8 is a common pair.

Linear equations $ax + by = c$

Theorem. Let a and b be positive integers with $d = \gcd(a, b)$. The equation $ax + by = c$ has integer solutions if and only if $d \mid c$. If (x_0, y_0) is one solution, then all the solutions are

$$x = x_0 + \frac{b}{d}t, \qquad y = y_0 - \frac{a}{d}t, \qquad t \in \mathbb{Z}.$$

Proof. If there is a solution, then d divides $ax + by = c$. Conversely, suppose $d \mid c$. Dividing everything by d, we may assume $\gcd(a, b) = 1$. By the theorem on inverses in L3-NT1, the congruence $ax \equiv c \pmod b$ has a solution x_0; then $c - ax_0$ is a multiple of b, say by_0, and (x_0, y_0) is a solution. Now let (x, y) be any solution of the original equation. Subtracting $ax_0 + by_0 = c$ gives $a(x - x_0) = b(y_0 - y)$, and dividing by d gives $\frac{a}{d}(x - x_0) = \frac{b}{d}(y_0 - y)$. Since $\frac{a}{d}$ and $\frac{b}{d}$ are coprime, $\frac{b}{d}$ divides $x - x_0$; writing $x - x_0 = \frac{b}{d}t$ forces $y_0 - y = \frac{a}{d}t$. Every integer t works. ■

So consecutive solutions differ by b/d in x and a/d in y, in opposite directions, and counting solutions with $x, y \geq 0$ means finding the range of t. To find the first solution, reduce modulo one of the coefficients.

Example 3. Pens cost 17p and pencils cost 11p. In how many ways can I spend exactly £10, buying at least one of each?

Solution.
We need positive integers x, y with $17x + 11y = 1000$. Guessing is slow with numbers this size, so we find one solution by working modulo 11. We have $17x \equiv 6x$ and $1000 = 90 \cdot 11 + 10$, so $6x \equiv 10 \pmod{11}$. Since $6 \cdot 2 = 12 \equiv 1$, the inverse of 6 is 2, and $x \equiv 20 \equiv 9 \pmod{11}$. Try $x = 9$: then $1000 - 153 = 847 = 11 \cdot 77$, so $(9, 77)$ is a solution.
Since $\gcd(17, 11) = 1$, the general solution is $x = 9 + 11t$, $y = 77 - 17t$. We need $x \geq 1$, so $t \geq 0$, and $y \geq 1$, so $17t \leq 76$, that is, $t \leq 4$. Hence $t = 0, 1, 2, 3, 4$, giving $(9, 77)$, $(20, 60)$, $(31, 43)$, $(42, 26)$ and $(53, 9)$. There are 5 ways.
The step sizes have a concrete meaning: 11 pens and 17 pencils both cost 187p, so swapping one bundle for the other keeps the total fixed.

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Bounding

When one side grows faster than the other, or the variables can be put in order, you get an inequality that leaves finitely many cases. Two habits help. If the equation is symmetric, assume an order such as $a \le b \le c$ and permute at the end. Then replace every variable by the largest (or smallest) one to obtain a bound.

Example 4. Find all triples of positive integers (a, b, c) with $a \le b \le c$ and $abc = 4(a+b+c)$.

Solution.
Three unknowns and one equation: we must bound something. Since c is the largest, $a+b+c \le 3c$, so $abc \le 12c$, and dividing by c gives $ab \le 12$. In particular $a^2 \le ab \le 12$, so $a \le 3$. Each of the three cases becomes a two-variable product equation.
If $a = 1$, then $bc = 4 + 4b + 4c$, so $(b-4)(c-4) = 20$. Neither factor is zero. If both were negative, then $b, c \le 3$ and the product would be at most $3 \cdot 3 = 9$, so both are positive. With $b \le c$ we need $(b-4)^2 \le 20$, so $b - 4 \in \{1, 2, 4\}$, giving $(b, c) = (5, 24), (6, 14), (8, 9)$.
If $a = 2$, then $2bc = 8 + 4b + 4c$, so $bc - 2b - 2c = 4$ and $(b-2)(c-2) = 8$. Here $b \ge 2$, and $b = 2$ would give $0 = 8$, so both factors are positive. With $b \le c$ we need $b - 2 \in \{1, 2\}$, giving $(b, c) = (3, 10)$ and $(4, 6)$.
If $a = 3$, then $3bc = 12 + 4b + 4c$, and this case needs one extra step. Multiply by 3 to complete the product: $9bc - 12b - 12c = 36$, so $(3b-4)(3c-4) = 52$. With $3 \le b \le c$ the first factor satisfies $5 \le 3b - 4 \le \sqrt{52} < 8$, and the only value of the form $3b - 4$ in that range is 5, which does not divide 52. No solutions.
So the solutions are $(1, 5, 24)$, $(1, 6, 14)$, $(1, 8, 9)$, $(2, 3, 10)$ and $(2, 4, 6)$, and each checks: for instance $2 \cdot 4 \cdot 6 = 48 = 4 \cdot 12$. A bound reducing to a few cases, followed by factorising in each case, is typical of the harder SMC and AIME questions.

Common traps.

- Forgetting negative factor pairs when the variables are any integers, or not ruling them out properly when they are positive.
- Ignoring parity in a difference of squares, and listing factor pairs that give non-integer x and y.
- Dividing by something that might be zero, such as $x - 3$ in the opening problem.
- Assuming $a \le b \le c$ when the equation is not symmetric, or forgetting to count the permutations when the question asks for ordered triples.
- Stopping once you have found some solutions. "Find all" means proving there are no others, and checking each candidate.
- In $ax + by = c$ with $\gcd(a, b) = d > 1$, stepping by b instead of b/d.

How to spot this in a contest

The main signal is "integers" or "positive integers" beside an equation with more unknowns than equations. Then read its shape.

- A product xy together with linear terms: complete the product.
- Squares and a constant, or "is a perfect square": a difference of squares, or a squeeze between consecutive squares.
- "Show that there are no solutions": try small moduli, usually 3, 4, 8, 9 and 7.

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- A symmetric equation in several variables: order them and bound.
- Coins, stamps or prices: a linear equation, solved with one particular solution plus the general step.

In the AMC, "how many ordered pairs" usually means counting divisors of a constant, doubled if negative factors are allowed.

Practice

Try each problem before turning to the hints and solutions at the back.

1. ⋆ How many ordered pairs of positive integers (x, y) satisfy $xy = 4x + 6y$?

2. ⋆⋆ How many of the integers $1, 2, 3, \ldots, 100$ can be written in the form $x^2 - y^2$, where x and y are integers?

3. ⋆⋆ A post office sells only 7p and 12p stamps. In how many different ways can a parcel be given exactly £5 of postage? (Two ways are the same if they use the same number of each stamp.)

4. ⋆⋆⋆ Find all positive integers n for which $n! + 5n + 13$ is a perfect square.

5. ⋆⋆⋆ Find all pairs of positive integers (x, y) such that $x^3 - y^3 = 721$.

6. ⋆⋆⋆⋆ How many ordered triples of positive integers (a, b, c) satisfy $\dfrac{1}{a} + \dfrac{1}{b} + \dfrac{1}{c} = \dfrac{7}{10}$?

Contest ladder

Real past problems that use this idea, easiest first. Open them on the official paper or the AoPS wiki, or online at kevinvariant08.github.io.

1. AMC 12A 2015 Problem 10 ⋆
2. AMC 10A 2006 Problem 22 ⋆⋆
3. AIME II 2012 Problem 1 ⋆⋆
4. AMC 12B 2020 Problem 8 ⋆⋆
5. AIME II 2000 Problem 2 ⋆⋆⋆
6. UKMT SMC 2026 Question 23 ⋆⋆⋆
7. AIME 1987 Problem 5 ⋆⋆⋆
8. AMC 10B 2023 Problem 14 ⋆⋆⋆
9. BMO1 2009/10 Problem 1 ⋆⋆⋆
10. BMO1 2012/13 Problem 4 ⋆⋆⋆
11. BMO1 2016/17 Problem 3 ⋆⋆⋆
12. BMO1 2018/19 Problem 3 ⋆⋆⋆⋆

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Hints

1. Move everything to one side and add a constant so that the left-hand side factorises.
2. Look at $x^2 - y^2$ modulo 4, and then try to write the allowed numbers explicitly.
3. Solve $7x + 12y = 500$ in non-negative integers. Working modulo 7 tells you what y must be.
4. For large n, $n!$ is divisible by many small numbers. Which modulus makes both $n!$ and $5n$ vanish?
5. Factorise the left-hand side. Then compare the sizes of the two factors to show that $x - y$ must be small.
6. Count the triples with $a \le b \le c$ first, using $\frac{3}{a} \ge \frac{7}{10}$ to bound a, then a similar bound for b in each case. Count orderings at the end.

Solutions

Problem 1

Answer: 8

The equation is $xy - 4x - 6y = 0$, and adding 24 to both sides gives $(x-6)(y-4) = 24$. Since $x, y \ge 1$, we have $x - 6 \ge -5$ and $y - 4 \ge -3$. Neither factor can be zero. If both were negative, their product would be at most $5 \cdot 3 = 15 < 24$, so both are positive. Then each positive divisor d of 24 gives exactly one solution, $x = 6 + d$ and $y = 4 + 24/d$. Since $24 = 2^3 \cdot 3$ has $4 \cdot 2 = 8$ positive divisors, there are 8 ordered pairs.

Problem 2

Answer: 75

Squares are 0 or 1 modulo 4, so $x^2 - y^2$ is never $\equiv 2 \pmod 4$. Every other number does work: an odd number is $2k+1 = (k+1)^2 - k^2$, and a multiple of 4 is $4k = (k+1)^2 - (k-1)^2$. Among $1, \ldots, 100$ there are 25 numbers that are $\equiv 2 \pmod 4$, namely $2, 6, \ldots, 98$. So the answer is $100 - 25 = 75$.

Problem 3

Answer: 6

We need non-negative integers with $7x + 12y = 500$. Modulo 7, we have $12 \equiv 5$ and $500 = 71 \cdot 7 + 3$, so $5y \equiv 3 \pmod 7$. The inverse of 5 modulo 7 is 3, since $15 \equiv 1$, so $y \equiv 9 \equiv 2 \pmod 7$. Conversely, any $y \equiv 2 \pmod 7$ with $12y \le 500$ makes $500 - 12y$ a non-negative multiple of 7. The condition $12y \le 500$ means $y \le 41$, and the values $y \equiv 2 \pmod 7$ in that range are $y = 2, 9, 16, 23, 30, 37$, giving $x = 68, 56, 44, 32, 20, 8$. So there are 6 ways.

Problem 4

Answer: n = 2

For $n \ge 5$, both $n!$ and $5n$ are multiples of 5, so $n! + 5n + 13 \equiv 13 \equiv 3 \pmod 5$. But the squares modulo 5 are $0^2 \equiv 0$, $(\pm 1)^2 \equiv 1$ and $(\pm 2)^2 \equiv 4$, so a square is never $\equiv 3 \pmod 5$. Hence $n \le 4$, and we check the four cases: $n = 1$ gives 19, $n = 2$ gives $25 = 5^2$, $n = 3$ gives 34 and $n = 4$ gives 57. The only answer is $n = 2$.

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Problem 5

Answer: (9, 2) and (16, 15)

Write $x^3 - y^3 = (x - y)(x^2 + xy + y^2)$. The second factor is positive, so $d = x - y$ is a positive divisor of $721 = 7 \cdot 103$. Since $x^2 + xy + y^2 > x^2 - 2xy + y^2 = d^2$, we get $721 = d(x^2 + xy + y^2) > d^3$, so $d \leq 8$, and therefore $d = 1$ or $d = 7$.

Substitute $x = y + d$, so that $x^2 + xy + y^2 = 3y^2 + 3dy + d^2$. If $d = 1$, then $3y^2 + 3y + 1 = 721$, so $y^2 + y = 240 = 15 \cdot 16$, giving $y = 15$ and $x = 16$. If $d = 7$, then $3y^2 + 21y + 49 = 103$, so $y^2 + 7y - 18 = 0$, that is, $(y + 9)(y - 2) = 0$, giving $y = 2$ and $x = 9$. Check: $16^3 - 15^3 = 4096 - 3375 = 721$ and $9^3 - 2^3 = 729 - 8 = 721$. The solutions are $(9, 2)$ and $(16, 15)$.

Problem 6

Answer: 21

First find the triples with $a \leq b \leq c$. Since $\frac{1}{a}$ is the largest of the three fractions, $\frac{3}{a} \geq \frac{7}{10}$, so $a \leq 4$; and $\frac{1}{a} < \frac{7}{10}$, so $a \geq 2$. In each case, $\frac{1}{b}$ is the larger of the two remaining fractions, so $\frac{2}{b}$ is at least what remains.

If $a = 2$, then $\frac{1}{b} + \frac{1}{c} = \frac{1}{5}$, so $5 < b \leq 10$. Here $\frac{1}{c} = \frac{b-5}{5b}$, which is a unit fraction for $b = 6$ (giving $c = 30$) and $b = 10$ (giving $c = 10$), but not for $b = 7, 8, 9$. If $a = 3$, then $\frac{1}{b} + \frac{1}{c} = \frac{11}{30}$, so $3 \leq b \leq \frac{60}{11}$, that is, $b \in \{3, 4, 5\}$. Then $\frac{1}{c} = \frac{11}{30} - \frac{1}{b}$ equals $\frac{1}{30}$, $\frac{7}{60}$ and $\frac{1}{6}$ respectively, so $b = 3, c = 30$ and $b = 5, c = 6$ work. If $a = 4$, then $\frac{1}{b} + \frac{1}{c} = \frac{9}{20}$, so $4 \leq b \leq \frac{40}{9}$, forcing $b = 4$ and $\frac{1}{c} = \frac{1}{5}$, so $c = 5$.

So the triples with $a \leq b \leq c$ are $(2, 6, 30)$, $(2, 10, 10)$, $(3, 3, 30)$, $(3, 5, 6)$ and $(4, 4, 5)$. Those with three different entries give 6 ordered triples each, and those with a repeated entry give 3 each. The total is $6 + 3 + 3 + 6 + 3 = 21$.

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